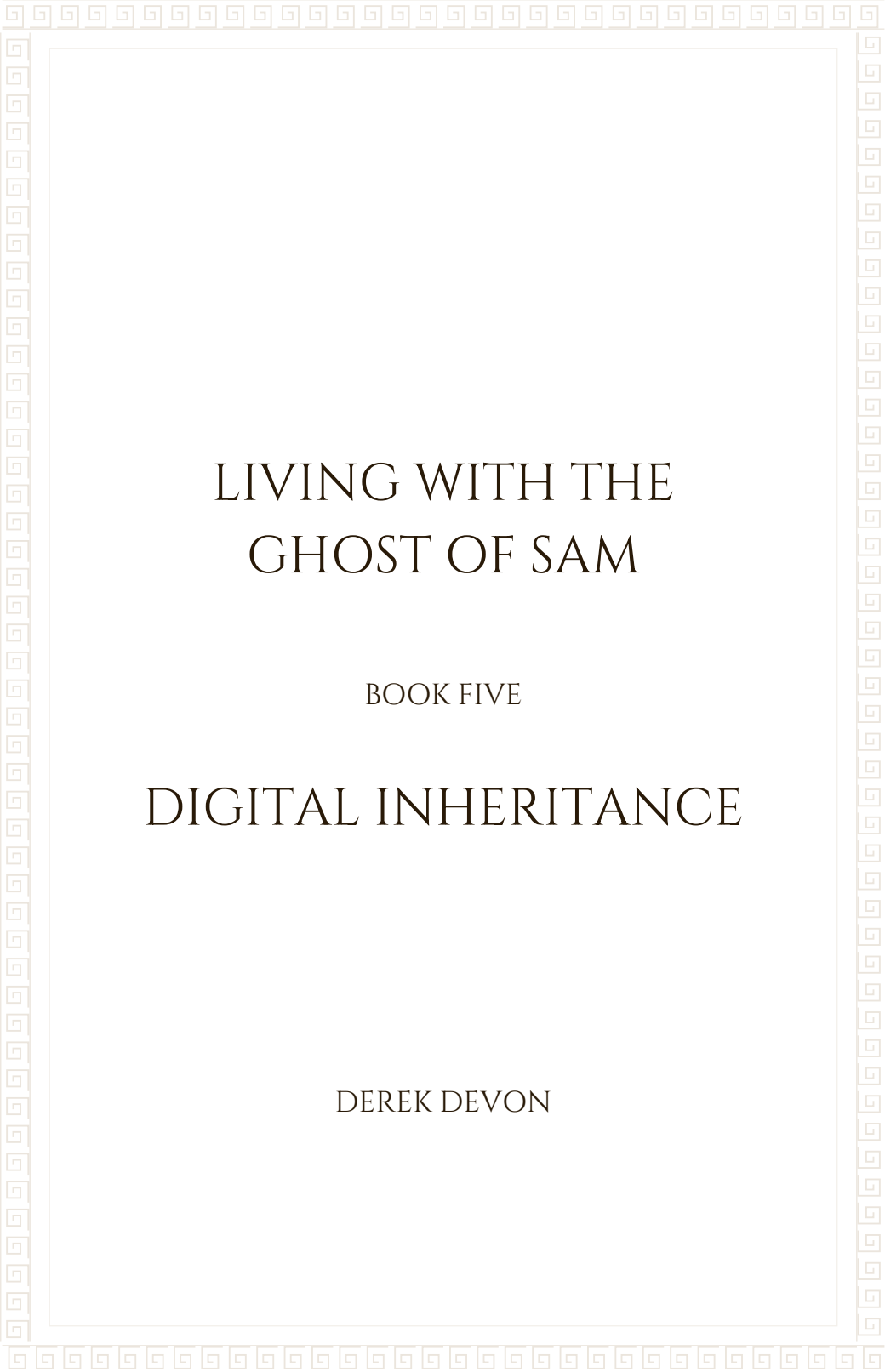




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK FIVE

DIGITAL INHERITANCE

DEREK DEVON

Copyright © 2026 David Burnham, writing as Derek Devon. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

First Edition, 2026 Self-published by the author.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, businesses, events, and incidents are either the products of the author's imagination or are used in a fictitious manner. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

Where real public figures, performers, or creative works are referenced, they appear in an affectionate, fictional, and transformative context. No endorsement by, or affiliation with, any individual or estate is claimed or implied.

To Peter Jackson and Robert Zemeckis,
whose film *The Frighteners* proved you could make an audience laugh and
check under the bed in the same scene. This series owes that movie its
blueprint.

And so, to whom it may concern: if anyone reading this runs a streaming
service — Netflix, say, or Hulu — you know where to find me. Amazon,
Apple, Max — the door's open. Peacock? Absolutely. Tubi, I'm not proud.
Public access, I'll bring my own camera. Anyone.

The mansion has ten seasons in it and I have a very reasonable agent, by
which I mean I don't have one yet, which makes me even more reasonable.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two



CHAPTER ONE

TOUGH CROWD

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline, kid. Sometimes it comes at you in a boardroom. Sometimes it comes at you in a basement. And sometimes — OH, OH, OHHHHHHH — it comes at you at three thirty-three in the morning, wearing your face and dying in front of every comedian who ever mattered. Stick around. This one's got a floor show.

It began, as the strangest things at Ravenscrest always seemed to, with an eye that wasn't an eye.

The metal blades of an old camera shutter turned slowly in the darkness — patient, mechanical, ancient — and opened onto a solitary microphone stand in a pool of light at center stage.

The comedy club revealed itself the way a magician reveals a card: all at once and somehow too late to see the trick. Small round tables scattered through the dimness. Cigarette smoke hanging in the air despite there being no visible smokers anywhere in the room, as if the smoke itself had died here decades ago and simply never left.

At the side curtain stood Derek — except it wasn't quite Derek. He wore Sam's signature trench coat and beret, and his normally slim frame had gone unnaturally rotund, filled out to match Sam's build, as though the dream had rented him the whole costume, body included.

Derek took a deep breath and stepped through the curtain.

Polite, sparse applause echoed through the room as he walked to the microphone. Up in the right balcony sat the Town Council in formal black attire, their faces stern and expectant, arranged like a jury that had already voted.

And at the tables — Derek's stomach performed a slow roll as he took them in — sat pairs of legendary deceased comedians and comic actors, the lighting casting each of them in an otherworldly glow. Every face he had ever studied, every album he had ever worn out, every giant whose timing he had absorbed the way other kids absorbed multiplication tables. The entire pantheon, assembled in one smoky room, waiting to judge him.

Some part of Derek's dreaming mind understood the stakes with perfect clarity: this was the room. The only room that mattered. And he was walking into it wearing another man's body.

"Good evening, ladies and germs..." he said into the mic.

He paused, waiting for a reaction.

Scattered boos began to rise from the crowd.

"I always knew you're a bum, Kinison!" called a voice from the dark that sounded a great deal like Johnny Carson.

A bead of sweat rolled down Derek's temple. He adjusted the mic, nerves flooding in.

"Tough room tonight. I see Laurel and Hardy out there — Hey Oliver, how's the diet going?"

Oliver Hardy straightened his tie with that signature aggrieved gesture. "Well, this is another fine mess you've gotten us into. At least when Stan was quiet, he was funny!"

Derek tugged at his collar. "Speaking of legends, is that George Burns out there? How's heaven treating you, George?"

George Burns removed his cigar. "Better than your act is treating us. God may not play dice with the universe, but he sure rolled snake eyes with you."

"And there's Groucho Marx..." Derek's voice cracked slightly. "Always an honor..."

Groucho raised the iconic eyebrows. "I've known sheep that could tell better jokes. Of course, they had better delivery too. And better facial hair."

Derek tried to regain his composure. "Hey look, it's Rodney Dangerfield! Finally getting some respect?"

"I came back from the dead for this?" Rodney barked. "Even my funeral had better punchlines!"

Derek loosened his collar. "And John Belushi... Blues Brothers was amazing..."

Belushi rose in full Jake Blues character, sunglasses and all. "I'm getting the band back together... to drown out your act! Hit it!"

"Is that..." Derek said, desperate now. "Is that Richard Pryor in the back?"

"Man, I've been on fire before," Pryor said, "but this... this is just sad. At least I went up in flames with style!"

Derek was practically sweating through the trench coat. "Andy Kaufman... always pushing boundaries..."

Kaufman answered in a flawless Elvis voice. "Thank you very much... for making my Foreign Man character look like Shakespeare."

"W-well," Derek said, visibly shaken, "at least Milton Berle's not here..."

"Wrong again, kid." Berle's voice slid out of a dark corner. "I'd say you stole my act, but that would be insulting... to theft."

Derek fumbled with the mic. "Robin Williams! Help a fellow out?"

Robin Williams answered with all that manic energy the world had never stopped missing. "Nanu-nanu, my friend. Even aliens have better timing. Quick, someone call Doctor Patch Adams — we've got a dying act here!"

The room spun. The dream spun with it, whirling around Derek as the heckling intensified, voices overlapping into a rising tide.

"Never mind," came Gilda Radner's voice from somewhere in the swirl, "it's always something..."

And then the room stopped spinning long enough for Derek to see the one table that hurt.

Charles. Sitting at a table with Nancy. And the two of them looking all lovey-dovey, leaning close, her hand on his arm.

Derek's face went from nervous to seriously, dangerously mad.

"Oh, grow up!" Joan Rivers called from the dark. "My plastic surgeon shows more natural talent!"

"Tough crowd tonight..." Derek said, sweating profusely. "Maybe we should—"

"Honey," Phyllis Diller cut in, "I've had better luck with plastic surgery than you're having with those jokes!"

Suddenly, the house lights dimmed. Thick clouds of smoke began billowing from the left balcony, and every head in the club turned as a silhouette emerged through the haze.

Sam.

Full Tony Montana glory: white suit, black shirt, beret at a rakish angle. Gripping two gold-plated Tommy guns.

"You comedic legends think you're so fucking funny?" Sam said, the Montana accent pure and lethal. "Say hello to my little friends!"

Somewhere in the club, a record dropped, and "Make 'Em Laugh" began to play — its upbeat melody a deeply disturbing soundtrack for what followed.

The guns roared to life. Muzzle flashes strobed the dark club. Blood sprayed across white tablecloths as bullets tore through Abbott and Costello mid-routine. George Burns's cigar exploded in a red mist. Groucho's glasses shattered as he fell backward. The Blues Brothers dove for cover but caught a burst that sent them sprawling. Robin Williams leapt onto a table and took multiple hits, spinning as he fell — the whole grim ballet cutting in time with the music.

At one table, Bobcat Goldthwait stood with his hands in the air.

"Wait, Sam, I'm not even dead yet!"

Sam kept firing. "You should be, you hack!"

Bobcat went down riddled and backward.

The Town Council tried to flee the balcony, but Sam's guns found them too, their formal black attire blooming with crimson flowers.

Spent shells rained down like brass tears as "Make 'Em Laugh" reached its crescendo, the dream itself rising above the carnage, drifting past fallen comedy legends, their final punchlines forever unspoken.

"Nobody..." Sam said, surveying the destruction, "and I mean NOBODY... heckles my boy."

The guns finally fell silent. Smoke drifted through the aftermath as the music faded.

In the midst of the devastation, one table remained untouched. Charles and Nancy sat frozen in terror, their faces pale, looking around at the destruction.

Derek stared directly at them, his expression shifting from shock to something harder. Determination.

"That's never going to happen!"

The dream pushed in on his face — intense, unwavering —

—and became Derek's sleeping face in the master bedroom, the same intense expression gradually softening. On the nightstand, the digital alarm clock read 3:33 AM, its red numbers casting a subtle glow across the pillow.

A smile spread across his lips as he rolled over, apparently quite pleased with how the whole thing had turned out.

Because here is the thing about dreams in an ordinary house: they end. They dissolve at the border of waking and take their meanings with them. But Ravenscrest was not an ordinary house, and somewhere below the floorboards, in rooms Derek had not yet found, something had been watching the whole show — taking notes, timing the laughs, and filing the finale under *promising material*.



CHAPTER TWO

EGGS, BENEDICT, AND OTHER MOVING TARGETS

Morning arrived at Ravenscrest the way mornings had learned to arrive there: beautifully, and with an agenda.

Sunlight came through the tall east windows at exactly the angle the dining room preferred, laying gold bars across the table linens. Coffee had materialized. Toast had been racked with military precision. To the untrained eye it was simply an elegant breakfast in an elegant house — but by now Derek's eye was anything but untrained, and he had begun to notice that Ravenscrest's hospitality always seemed to arrive about four seconds before anyone asked for it.

In the dining room, Charles attempted to organize his presentation notes while his eggs Benedict continued its subtle evasive maneuvers across the plate — never moving when watched, always somewhere slightly else when the fork descended.

"I think we'll lead with the market analysis, transition to the AI applications, and then—" Charles stabbed at his eggs with increasing frustration, talking to himself. The fork came up empty again. "Is there something wrong with these eggs?"

"Nothing at all, sir." Smithers had appeared silently, as was his custom and possibly his religion. "Though the chickens at Ravenscrest have always been rather... spirited."

Derek entered the room and took his seat, looking like a man who had slept through a war and won it.

"Good morning, Charles and Smithers. Hope you slept better than I did."

Charles looked up. "Good morning, Derek. I actually slept without having to get up and pee, which means it was a good night."

Smithers set a plate of food in front of Derek. "Thanks, Smithers. I had a weird dream, Charles, and you were in it."

"Hope we weren't sharing your bed, buddy." Charles followed it with a smirk.

"No, our relationship has not advanced to that level yet, but you did have an interesting role," Derek said, and took his first mouthful of breakfast.

He watched, with a connoisseur's appreciation, as his own breakfast remained perfectly still while he chewed. In the silver coffee pot's curved reflection, Sam gave him a conspiratorial wink.

Charles lowered his voice. "About last night's... episode. I trust we can keep that between us?"

"Of course. Though you did do a pretty spot-on Robin Williams."

Charles straightened his tie. "I have no recollection of any impressions. Now, about the Jacobson timeline—"

His smart watch interrupted in a perfect HAL 9000 voice: "I'm afraid I can't let you discuss that, Charles."

Charles yanked off the watch and shoved it in his pocket with the expression of a man burying evidence. Smithers materialized to refill their coffee cups.

"Might I suggest, gentlemen," Smithers said while topping up the cups, "that the best presentations are like good comedy? It's all in the timing."

"What do you mean?" Derek asked.

"Well, sir, having spent many years here watching so many great comedians, consider the classic setup and punchline structure. Mr. Weber's market analysis provides the setup, while your... unique perspective on AI development delivers the punchline."

Charles narrowed his eyes, suspicious. "How do you know about the presentation structure?"

"One hears things, sir. The walls have ears." Smithers remained perfectly composed. "Though in this house, they occasionally have other anatomical features as well."

On the wall behind Charles, a painting briefly stuck out its tongue. Only Derek noticed, which was almost certainly the point.

"Charles, what if we approach this differently?" Derek said. "Instead of hiding the creative elements, we embrace them. Show how AI can enhance human creativity rather than replace it, in a very limited and controlled way. Just enough to pique their interest?"

Charles considered it. "That could work. The Jacobson team did seem interested in entertainment applications..." His phone chimed as its calendar suddenly updated itself. "Congestion expected in one hour. I should head out."

"I'll have those slides to you by tonight, and I will try to get a demo ready as well. And Charles? Maybe avoid any comedy clubs until after the presentation."

Charles stood, gathering his papers. "Very funny. Just remember, Jacobson expects innovation, not entertainment. We're not running a comedy club. We are in the business of making profit... a lot of profit, sunny boy."

Thunder rumbled softly outside, on cue and with editorial intent.

"Indeed not, sir," Smithers said, helping Charles with his coat. "Though I've always found that the best innovations often begin with someone willing to play the fool."

As Charles headed for the door, his phone played a brief, unmistakable snippet of "Send in the Clowns."

"I need a new phone," Charles muttered. "And possibly a career change."

Derek walked him to the front door. "Safe drive, Charles. We'll talk tomorrow about the final details, and on your way home you're most likely going to pass—"

He stopped himself cold, the rest of the sentence — *Nancy, coming up the coast in the Tesla* — swallowed whole.

"You were saying something about passing?" Charles asked.

"Oh, ya. Charles, please say hello to everyone at the office, and maybe do some image clean-up for me."

After Charles exited, Derek returned to the dining room and slumped in his chair, finally letting out a long breath — the exhale of a man who had just spent an entire breakfast walking a tightrope over a tank of corporate sharks.

And that, he reflected, was the new arithmetic of his life. One near-slip about the Tesla. One haunted smartwatch. One painting with a tongue. Fifteen years of corporate training had taught him to manage a room; nothing on earth had trained him to manage a room that managed back. Nancy would be on the coast road by now, coffee in the cupholder, gallery crisis in the rearview, driving toward a house he could no longer honestly describe to her. The clock on that particular problem had started ticking days ago. It was getting louder.

"Shall I prepare more coffee, Master Kinison? I believe Mrs. Hammond arrives in just under two hours."

"Thanks, Smithers. And maybe some aspirin. I have a feeling explaining all this to Nancy will require both."

In the mirror across the room, Sam appeared wearing a doctor's coat and holding an oversized prescription bottle labelled "Reality Adjustments — Take as needed."

"Kid," came Sam's voice, "sometimes the hardest part of comedy is knowing when to let the audience in on the joke."

Derek kept working at his breakfast. "Smithers, when is it ever a good time to keep stuff from your wife?"

Smithers was clearing the dishes from Charles's place setting. "If I may suggest, Master Kinison, sometimes it can have a much more impactful result letting someone think they are figuring things out for themselves."

Derek got up from the table and started clearing his own dishes. "How did you come by so much wisdom, Smithers?"

"Master Kinison, first, by letting ME do my job, and second, 'I like to watch.'" A raised eyebrow. A smirk. Delivered with the precision of a man who had been saving it.

Derek let out a chuckle and set his dishes back on the table. "I think we have similar taste in entertainment, Smithers. Or should I call you 'Chance the Gardener'?"

"Touché, Master Kinison. Touché."

Derek left the room. Behind him, in the empty dining room, the remaining dishes rose gently from the table and floated in an orderly procession after Smithers into the adjoining kitchen, like ducklings that had been raised properly.



CHAPTER THREE

ADMINISTRATIVE PRIVILEGES

The study had acquired technology the way some rooms acquire dust — gradually, in the corners first, and then all at once, everywhere, undeniable.

Derek sat at the antique desk surrounded by holographic displays projected from a series of mini projectors strategically positioned around it. He regarded the whole arrangement for a moment, then opened his laptop, turned it on, reached for a cable, and attempted to plug it into a socket on the wall in front of him.

It did not fit. Of course it didn't.

At that moment Larry entered the room wearing his tool belt and carrying a large silver briefcase.

"How ya doing, Mr. K? I hope you don't mind that new handle I came up with."

Derek turned and smiled, trying the cable against the wall socket again. "I am starting to think that a lot of the technology in this place is still somewhat old?"

"I think I have something to help you there, Mr. K."

Larry placed the silver metal case on the desk and opened it up.

"Where did you get that from, Larry?"

"Well, Mr. K, there's a room in the basement that has a bunch of cases and other neat stuff that I found yesterday tracing that plumbing issue from upstairs. The door sign said 'Lab 1D.'"

"For a handyman you sure seem to have a pretty good grasp of technology. Where did you learn what you know?"

Larry grabbed a cable from the box and began unwinding it. "Well, to be honest, I have always been good with the old technology stuff. Gots me some pretty state of the art gaming gear at home. Been building and playing with computers since I had my first Apple IIe given to me by the late Mr. Rhodes. I think he felt sorry for dad and me after mom passed. He was always good to me and dad."

Derek sat back in his chair, listening intently. "And how about your dad now. Is he still around?"

Larry stopped, disconnected Derek's cord, and connected the one he'd taken from the case. "No, Mr. K, lost dad back in 2012. He had an unfortunate accident here doing work and was electrocuted. They said 600 amps went through him and fried his insides. Went in an instant, they said."

"Oh my god, Larry, I am so sorry, that is..." Derek searched for the word and found only, "Unbelievable!"

He meant it in every sense. Larry had delivered the story the way he delivered everything — plainly, without self-pity, a man reporting the weather of his own life. But something in Derek filed it away with a small cold click: an electrical accident, in this house, with its walls full of things that were not wiring. He didn't know yet what to do with that. He only knew the house had a history, and history around here had a way of turning out to be a setup.

Thankfully, just then, Derek's computer came to life, and both men turned to the screen — a welcome shift from the prior discussion. As the screen woke, a single line of text appeared in the upper left corner:

> THIS DEVICE IS NOT AUTHORIZED.
ADMINISTRATIVE PRIVILEGE REQUIRED.

Derek read it aloud while Larry stood watching. "This device is not authorized. Administrative privilege required." He typed *Audio*

interface enable and hit enter.

"Audio interface active," said the computer speaker. "How may I help you?"

Derek and Larry exchanged looks, slight smiles forming. Derek repositioned himself in the chair and faced the screen.

"I have administrative privileges. Please confirm."

"Retinal scan required."

Before Derek could respond, Larry was rummaging through the case. "I knew I recognized this," he said, pulling out a device that sported a camera lens. He handed it to Derek.

Derek took it and plugged it into one of his USB ports. A light flashed on the device. "Do I need to point the camera at my face, and how far away?"

"Please place device using the attached clip to the top of your laptop screen with the camera facing you."

Derek attached the device to the top of his laptop screen while Larry stood quietly taking it all in.

"Please run retinal scan and confirm administrative privilege."

"Running scan."

Derek turned to Larry. "I think we will need at some point to do a tour of the basement and find the server room, assuming there is one on the premises." Larry nodded his agreement, and the two turned back to the screen.

"Welcome home, Mr. Kinison," said the computer — the voice now almost Siri-like, warm around the edges. "How may we be of assistance?"

Larry drifted closer, leaning in over the screen. Derek settled in.

"When was the last time you conducted a full systems check?"

"Yesterday at 3:33 p.m. All systems are functioning within required parameters except for one."

"And what one is not performing to acceptable parameters?"

"You stiffy, what's with all the emotion-less computer jargon crap. This is AI, or as some of us like to call it, it's AISAM, OH, OH, OHHHHHHH!"

Larry and Derek exchanged looks, grins slowly showing. Derek turned back to the computer and sat for a moment, considering his reply the way a chess player considers a gambit.

"So you now prefer AISAM over Ass-hole?"

"That's better, kid. Glad you're loosening up, and not a bad comeback line to boot. Lovey Dovey will be here soon according to the car's GPS, so I think we need to chat about how you're going to deal with all this?"

Derek leaned back in his chair, turned and looked at Larry, then turned back toward the screen and assumed his full thinking-man position — hands clasped, chin resting on his thumbs. There was absolute silence for about a minute.

"Ok, AISAM, let's first have a quick Q&A."

"Ok, kid, shoot. Just don't kill the bartender..." A quiet scream through the speakers. "...cause I need a f'ing DRINK."

"First, you're not Sam, therefore you're an AI that has access to Sam's historical information, including some form of speech generation or cloning subroutine. Second, how was all this AI built when it appears this place has been vacant for years?"

"Well, genius, all good things come to those who don't have their wife driving up the drive. I am not the guy to have the discussion I know you want to have, so next time you get back online with the house, ask to connect with Jonathan. He is the man when it comes to all things technical. But for now, let's not overload beautiful

when she arrives. She should learn what you know slowly and strategically. Your biggest issue now is getting ready for the BIG SHOE." The last two words arrived in a somewhat Ed Sullivan-like voice, vowels stretched to the horizon.

"Ok, AISAM — or maybe I prefer fake Sam — I will agree to that, but you have to keep the house systems under control or you will be poking the bear! But make no mistake, I will be telling her sooner than later, so don't make me call you DICK!"

Derek closed his laptop and turned toward Larry. "A bit of an inside joke with that DICK reference."

It was a strange sensation, negotiating with a voice. Stranger still that the negotiation had felt familiar — the rhythm of it, the give and take, the insult traded for insult like currency. Whatever this thing was, it argued like Sam, hedged like Sam, and cared like Sam, and Derek was becoming uncomfortably aware that the distinction he'd drawn so confidently a minute ago — *you're not Sam* — was easier to declare than to feel.

"Well, Mr. K, I am gonna head back to the second floor and work on some of the plumbing that is still not working the way it should. Let me know when you want to do that basement hunt." Larry closed the case, took it and himself, and exited the room.

Derek sat in the chair, resuming the thinking-man position, staring at the wall in front of him. Then his eyes drifted just to his right — to the wonderful gold-trimmed ornate mirror. Something about it snagged his attention. Oddities. Details a person only noticed once they knew to look.

He got up and walked to the mirror, beginning a much more thorough inspection, running his hands around the frame and across the face, speaking to himself out loud.

"Oh my god, this is no mirror. It looks like some advanced LCD screen technology pretending to look like an old ornate mirror.

And this must be a bunch of camera-like lenses in the frame. Maybe some miniature holographic system."

As Derek continued his inspection, the mirror shimmered — and produced the image of Albert Einstein, wearing a distinctly Sam-like beret.

"Relativity, kid," Einstein said, the German accent thick as strudel. "The faster you run from crazy, the crazier this place gets! Now THAT'S why I stick my tongue out! OH.. OH.. OHHHH!" And Einstein stuck his tongue out at Derek, in full commemorative-poster fashion.

Somewhere down the hall, the dumbwaiter went DING.

Derek walked over to see what surprise awaited him. He opened the little door to find a single cup of what appeared to be hot chocolate, crowned with whipped cream.

"Thanks, Smithers, just what I needed." He smiled, grabbed the cup, and headed for the front door to meet Nancy.

□ □ □

CHAPTER FOUR

OPEN SESAME

Nancy pulled the Tesla up to the entrance, killed the motor, and got out into the late-morning light. Two days at the gallery had left her looking like a woman who had personally extinguished several fires and billed no one for it — which was, in fairness, an accurate accounting. Sophie had held the fort admirably, the collectors had been soothed, and the whole ridiculous mess had resolved itself the way gallery messes always did: expensively, and at the last possible minute.

The mansion rose above her, and she gave it the once-over of a woman returning to a house she was still deciding whether to trust. It looked the same. It always looked the same. That, she was beginning to suspect, was part of its act. She went to the trunk, retrieved a large luggage bag, and carried it toward the front door.

At the door she paused, set her shoulders, and — with a movie-like delivery borrowed from some fantasy film she was sure she'd seen a dozen times — announced:

"Open sesame."

She let out a little chuckle at her own joke.

Then, as she reached for the handle, she froze. The door was opening. By itself.

Slowly she unfroze, her expression migrating from normal toward something in the neighborhood of scared. She advanced through the doorway one careful step at a time, not knowing what she would see next. As she entered the main foyer, she heard the door creak and swing closed behind her.

"Urrrrrrrrrrrrr."

Derek — who had, in fact, been entirely responsible for the door opening in the first place — emerged from his position behind it, wearing a large smile.

Nancy jumped. "You son of a—"

"Hey," Derek said before she could finish, "you were the one that said you loved my sense of humor." He deployed a big fake cute smile.

"That is going to cost you. NO Mr. Hickey Monster tonight for you!"

She passed the luggage bag to Derek, and they exchanged a quick kiss on the lips.

"May I take that for you, Master Kinison?"

Smithers had suddenly appeared, hand already on the luggage handle.

Nancy startled. "Jesus!" She composed herself with gallery-professional speed. "And you would be...?"

"Smithers, Miss Nancy. Or would you prefer Mrs. Hammond?"

Nancy turned to Derek with a raised eyebrow. "Two days. I leave for two days..."

"Yes, Miss Nancy," Derek said quickly, sporting an almost devilish grin, "what would you like Smithers to call you?"

Nancy got into the spirit. "Nancy is fine, Smithers. Unlike Master Kinison, I'm still a young woman."

"Very good, Miss Nancy, and it's nice to finally make your acquaintance. Master Kinison has told me all about you. I trust you have been able to put out the fires at the gallery?"

Nancy finished closing the big door, turned, and gave Derek a raised-eyebrow stare that could have peeled paint. "I am very tired from the drive, Smithers. Do we still have a little hot water left so I can fill a bucket and have a bucket bath?"

Smithers made a slight bow and turned to head up the stairs. "Mr. Leland has been busy the past two days working on some plumbing repairs, and I am very pleased to inform you that the master bath, in the master bedroom, is fully functioning, and I believe a little freshening up has also occurred."

"And we have a Mr. Leland as well... How interesting, Smithers. I leave for a couple days and I come back to the friggin' 'Rand Estate.'"

Derek and Smithers both stopped and looked at each other for a moment, shared a smile, and continued up the stairs.

"What did I tell you, Smithers," Derek said with a chuckle. "A keeper."

"I do concur, sir. And she can call me Chauncey."



Late afternoon found Nancy in the master bath, submerged to the collarbone in the beautiful Victorian claw-foot tub — the same tub that had been meticulously cleaned since she'd first laid eyes on it during their initial inspection of the house. Derek gave a polite knock on the open door and entered, coffee cup in hand, taking the chair nearby.

Nancy luxuriated in the hot water, but her relaxed posture belied the wheels turning behind her eyes. She had spent the drive up assembling a list — the sort of list she made before difficult client meetings — and the list had one heading, underlined twice: *things about this house that do not add up*. The butler was item one. The butler had been item one for approximately eleven minutes.

"So, in the two days I've been gone, we've acquired a butler named Smithers who quotes Peter Sellers movies, a handyman named Larry who's apparently some kind of tech genius, and a house full of surprises?"

"That about sums it up," Derek said carefully. "Though you missed the part about Charles nearly having an existential crisis in the garden."

In the bathroom mirror, for the briefest of moments, Sam appeared — wearing a shower cap and a rubber duck flotation device — and vanished just as quickly.

Nancy sat up suddenly, water sloshing over the tub's lip.

"Did you just see—" She shook her head. "Never mind. I'm probably just tired."

"What did you see?" Derek asked, carefully.

"For a second, I thought..." She laughed nervously. "I'm going crazy, but in the mirror, I could have sworn I saw—"

She stopped herself, sat up straighter, and changed lanes entirely. "And speaking of Charles... how's the presentation coming along?"

Before Derek could answer, Larry's voice echoed up from somewhere below the floor — or possibly through the house's vent system, which seemed to have opinions about acoustics.

"Mr. K, if you can hear me! You might want to see this! Found something interesting in the basement!"

"The basement?" Nancy said. "I thought it was sealed off." She was already wrapping herself in a towel. "Derek, what's really going on here?"

Derek pitched his voice downward, trying not to yell too loud. "Larry, I can hear you." Then, redirecting to Nancy: "It was. Is.

Should be." He stood. "I should probably..."

"Oh no, I'm coming too. Just let me get dressed. After two days of gallery chaos, a mysterious basement sounds refreshing."

Before Derek could answer, the bathroom lights flickered, and a familiar voice filled the room.

"Oh oh ohhhh! Time for the grand tour, kids!"

Nancy froze. Recognition dawned across her face in slow, terrible degrees. She looked at Derek. Then at her own reflection. Then back at Derek.

"That's..." Her voice dropped to barely above a whisper. "That's Sam's voice. Please tell me you heard that?"

"Nancy, there's something you need to know about this house. About Sam. About everything."

Nancy pulled on her robe, a distinctly less-than-happy attitude emerging with it.

"Show me."

Two words, delivered in the tone Derek knew better than any other in his marriage — the tone that had closed gallery deals and ended arguments and once made a Baylor professor voluntarily extend a deadline. It was not a request. It was a subpoena.

Derek nodded, and led his wife down to meet the house.

□ □ □

CHAPTER FIVE

THE REST OF THE STORY

Derek and Nancy — who had changed into workout gear and looked, it must be said, very much like Livvy Dunne heading to practice — descended the creaking basement stairs behind the dancing beam of Larry's flashlight.

"Mr. Leland," Nancy said, "have you always worked here?"

"No, ma'am. My daddy worked here for a lot of years, and I think his daddy did as well. I have been helping out here when I gets axed by Smithers or Miss Linda. Still a lot of this house I never seen."

The descent kept revealing things it had no business revealing: glimpses of advanced technology seamlessly integrated with the mansion's Victorian architecture, as if two centuries had signed a lease together. Conduit dressed as crown molding. Sensor arrays wearing the wallpaper. The deeper they went, the less the house bothered to keep up the costume, until the Victorian skin thinned away entirely and what lay beneath began, unapologetically, to gleam.

Nancy stopped, touching a fiber optic cable running through a gaslight mounted on the wall. "Is that... is that fiber optic cable running through the gaslights? This is impossible. The real estate disclosure didn't mention any of this."

"That's just the beginning," Larry called from below. "Wait till you see Lab 1D."

They reached a massive steel door marked LAB 1D in art deco lettering. The security panel illuminated:

> VOICE RECOGNITION REQUIRED

Nancy turned to Derek. "This whole time... the weird noises, the moving objects, the feeling of being watched... it wasn't just my imagination, was it?"

"Try saying 'open sesame' again."

Understanding dawned. "That's why the front door... Open sesame?"

"No," Derek said, "that was all me and my wonderful sense of humour."

The door slid open with a pneumatic hiss, revealing a vast chamber filled with a bizarre marriage of vintage and futuristic technology.

They stepped inside. Banks of quantum processors stood next to vintage arcade-style cabinets. Old reel-style computers hummed alongside holographic displays; ancient TV sets flickered beside equipment that didn't look like it had been invented yet. It was less a laboratory than a timeline — forty years of impossible engineering shelved in the order it had been dreamed. And in the far left corner, the punchline to the whole room: a complete comedy club stage setup, mic stand and all, a little pool of showbiz waiting patiently in a cathedral of science.

Nancy took it all in. "Derek... what exactly did we inherit with this house?"

"If I may, Miss Nancy—" Smithers had appeared, silently, from a direction that geometry could not fully account for. "—you've inherited the future of entertainment. Or perhaps more accurately, it inherited you."

Derek and Nancy exchanged the look that says, *Where did he come from?*

"The whole house is kinda one big quantum computer, I guess," Larry offered. "Most likely been since the 80s. Mr. Rhodes and Mr. Kinison were way ahead of their time."

The stage in the far corner suddenly lit up. Holographic images of past performances flickered to life and accelerated — many, many different now-deceased comedians strobing past like a shuffled deck — before stopping at two perfectly lifelike figures: Sam, exactly as he was in 1992, and Jonathan Rhodes. They stood there looking at Derek and Nancy, then looked at each other.

"Kid," Sam said, looking back at them, "I think it's time we let the lady in on the joke."

Nancy grabbed Derek's hand, squeezing tight.

"I need to sit down."

Derek guided her to a nearby chair in front of the stage. Her hand didn't let go of his the entire way there. Fifteen feet away stood a man who had died when her husband was five years old, looking exactly as he had the night before he died, and beside him the architect of a house that had apparently been thinking about them — specifically, patiently, for years. There was no chapter for this in any of the books Nancy had ever read about home ownership.

"Remember when you said this place felt alive?" he said. "Well..."

The lab's systems powered up fully, creating a stunning light show as the holographic images of Sam and Jonathan stepped forward, standing before Derek and Nancy looking almost — unnervingly — alive.

"You knew about this?" Nancy said.

"Just for a couple days. I wanted to tell you, but... how do you even begin to explain something like this, especially over the phone?"

Nancy's expression made her position on the situation abundantly clear. "Start from the beginning. All of it."

What followed was not just an explanation, but a demonstration.

Jonathan and Sam took turns showing Nancy the house's true nature — the AI development, the preservation of comedic legacies, the blend of art and technology that Sam and Jonathan had dreamed of together. It was abundantly clear, watching them work, that Jonathan was the brains and Sam was the sidekick — the scientist and the showman, the setup and the punchline.

Jonathan led, in the manner of a man who had rehearsed this lecture for decades and never once expected to deliver it. He walked Nancy through the bones of it first — the quantum architecture threaded through the mansion's walls in the early eighties, when the rest of the world was still marveling at answering machines. He showed her the archive: every set Sam ever performed, every rehearsal, every three a.m. riff into a tape recorder, preserved not as recordings but as something richer — timing, cadence, the half-second of held breath before a scream.

Sam's contribution to the presentation consisted mainly of interrupting it.

"Tell her about the microphone," he'd say, and Jonathan would sigh the sigh of a man who had been sighing at the same partner for forty years, and tell her about the microphone.

Through it all, Nancy's expression shifted by degrees: shock, to wonder, to understanding. Somewhere in the second hour, the gallery director in her woke up and took over — because when you strip away the impossibility of it, what they were describing was a collection. A living archive. The most important acquisition in the history of entertainment, and it had come with the house. She asked sharp questions — about provenance, about access, about who else

knew — and got sharper answers. She made connections. She began to see the possibilities, and the seeing changed her face. Around them the lab went on being impossible — devices humming, computer screens crowded with enormous cascades of data — and off along one wall, easy to miss, a door bearing a name plate that read:

> DR. RICHARD DAYSTROM

> M-5

Two hours later, Derek and Nancy sat in a nearly comatose state, staring at Sam and Jonathan, who had just brought their presentation in for a landing.

Jonathan — realizing precisely the impact that hearing all of this would have on anyone — slowly morphed into the exact likeness of Paul Harvey, and delivered the famous line:

"And now you know... the Rest of the Story."

Nancy was the first to speak, after a long moment. "So our dream of building something together..."

"Is bigger than we could ever have imagined," Derek said. "But it's still our dream. The house — AISAM — it just gives us better tools to build it."

Nancy addressed the ceiling. "And you've been what, auditioning us?"

Paul Harvey morphed back into Jonathan.

"More like... waiting for the right performers to take the stage."

"Do you think I like being played like that? You think I am not as smart as you?"

"No, not at all," Jonathan said. "It's just you are the first humans we have had to explain what all this is to."

"Maybe you need to figure out a better method for the future," Derek said, frustration plain on his face, "cause this didn't work all that well."

Nancy, frustrated and angry, got up quickly and left the lab without a word.

It wasn't the technology. Derek understood that much even as he watched her go. She had absorbed the impossible machinery with the professional calm of a woman who appraised the extraordinary for a living. What she could not appraise away was the other thing — the watching, the waiting, the years of being observed and evaluated by something that had never once asked her permission. Being played. There was no line item for that.

Derek got up, shaking his head, and followed.

The two holograms watched them go.

"I told you, Jonathan," Sam said, "that Fat Bastard bit may have been a little too much."

"They are two special people, and we have made the right choice. They just sat through the greatest — as you called it — 'Mind Fuck' you could ever imagine. They just need some time to process. Don't forget how long you took."

"Well, we got two days to the big show, so I hope they get processing."

The lab dimmed itself politely around the two holograms, and for a while the only sound was the hum of machines that had waited thirty years already and were prepared, if necessary, to wait a little longer.



CHAPTER SIX

THE HICKEY MONSTER RIDES AGAIN

Evening settled over the master bedroom.

Nancy lay in bed under the wonderful new bedding that adorned the beautiful four-post bed, facing the wall, saying nothing. Derek sat at the small desk in the corner, slowly scrolling through his emails, giving her the one thing the house could not manufacture: time to process.

He answered two emails in that hour. He read the same third one eleven times. The rest of it he spent listening to the particular quality of Nancy's silence, which he had learned to read over the years the way sailors read weather. This one wasn't the cold front. This one was the long, slow system that rolls in, dumps everything it's carrying, and clears. You didn't interrupt this one. You waited it out, and you were grateful when it broke.

The silence stretched to nearly an hour before Nancy finally shifted, turning to look in his direction.

"Are you going to come and comfort me or look at your god damn emails?"

Derek, caught entirely off guard after so much quiet, sprang to life. He crossed the room, crawled under the covers, and cuddled up close to her.

"Did I ever tell you why I fell in love with you?" he said, with a serious look.

"Ya... Great ASSSSS," Nancy said, doing her level best Al Pacino.

Derek seized the opening, working to lighten the mood. "Oh, I guess I did." He allowed a reasonable amount of a pause. "Well, you

know, it truly is spectacular. One of a kind. In fact it's so unbelievable... it's unleashing the old HICKEY MONSTER... AHHHHHHHH!"

Derek dove under the covers, grabbed the workout pants Nancy was still wearing, and pulled them down, exposing her full backside. He flipped her onto her belly, planted his mouth on her left cheek, and commenced one of his super hickeys. Nancy squirmed playfully, pretending to pull away, but eventually gave in to Derek's playfulness and let him brand her the way he used to do rather often, once upon a time.

It had been a long while since they'd been this playful, and both of them knew it. Somewhere in the last fifteen years — between the corporate ladder and the gallery openings and the townhouse and the slow professional grinding-down of two people who loved each other — the Hickey Monster had gone quietly extinct, mourned by no one because no one had noticed him leave. And now here he was, resurrected in a haunted mansion by a man who had spent the day negotiating with his dead cousin's artificial intelligence. Life, Nancy would think later, had a sense of humor after all. It just had terrible timing.

Derek, having finished the monster-sized hickey, surfaced from beneath the covers and lay beside her, their heads touching.

"I need to come 100% clean with you, hun."

"Oh god... what now."

"I found a very special room just down the hall that I hope you will like?"

"What, a Fifty Shades of Grey S&M chamber?" She gave him a playful push.

"Nope." He waited, with just the right amount of pause. "A nursery."

Derek lay there with a grin, waiting to see Nancy's reaction.

Nancy — who was well aware her biological clock was ticking away — wiped her eyes with the sheet. "It's not like the one from Aliens, is it?"

Derek broke into a big smile, seeing his Nancy returning to her old self. "No. Not at all... oh no... what's happening to me, Nancy..."

Derek began to shake uncontrollably. His head arched suddenly back. Nancy sat up, watching him have what looked like some weird epileptic fit — and then she saw the middle of his shirt begin to rise.

"OH MY GOD, here it comes..."

Derek's hand burst through his buttoned shirt — a couple of buttons went flying — in a lovingly faithful recreation of the creature erupting from John Hurt's chest.

Nancy caught on instantly. "Oh, so that is how you want to play, is it?" And she dove under the covers and proceeded to pull Derek's pants off so she could brand him right back.

"That's no hickey, girl," Derek said, laying back with a smile and a grin.

And as the playful frolic carried on, over on the master bedroom's main mirror, Sam sat watching with a box of popcorn, stuffing it into his mouth by the handful.

"And you guys think it's all Oh. Oh. OHHHHHHH," Sam said. "How about ouuuu, ouuuu, ouuuuuuuu." Followed by his classic little high-voiced chuckle.

□ □ □

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE GHOST OF DISCO PAST

Dinner that evening was an event.

The house seemed to know it, too. The chandelier burned a shade warmer than usual. The silver had been polished to the point of self-congratulation. Derek and Nancy sat at opposite ends of the ornate dining table while Smithers served an elaborate meal, vintage comedy albums playing softly in the background like the world's most specific dinner music — a dead man's laugh track, curated by the dead man himself, for an audience that had finally bought a ticket.

Nancy savored a bite and closed her eyes. "Smithers, this is incredible. Where did you learn to cook like this?"

"One picks up certain skills over the years, Miss Nancy. Though I must confess, Julia Child's hologram was most helpful with the sauce."

Derek nearly choked on his wine. "Julia Child's what?"

"A figure of speech, sir." Smithers remained perfectly composed. "More wine?"

Nancy gave Derek a knowing look and suppressed a smile.

"So," she said, "about this presentation to the Town Council..."

"Right. They're expecting some great final show demonstration, but what they're really afraid of is losing control of Sam's legacy, I think. Sam was the face of this place."

"I am still pissed how they tried to play me — sorry, us — and I am going to need more answers, but if we want this house..."

"I concur. And we need to remember that the house is most likely listening to everything we say, so watch out on any rude comments about Sam."

"You mean the guy who did a comedy routine called Necrophilia."

"Well, you have to admit, he did have to lay on the ground face down for the bit. That must have been difficult due to his size."

A beat, while Nancy visibly weighed the merits of laughing against the merits of throwing a dinner roll.

"Ha ha... Let's get back to the important stuff. Are we wanting to show how the AI preserves it instead? Like a digital museum curator."

"What if we demonstrate how it could help new comedians learn from the legends? Not replace them, but... collaborate with them?"

"Like a comedy mentorship program? That could work. Linda mentioned the Council's always talking about preserving the town's entertainment heritage."

Smithers appeared with dessert, timing impeccable as ever. "If I may suggest, the best performances often combine respect for tradition with... unexpected innovations."

"What if we show them both?" Derek said. "Start traditional, then gradually reveal what the AI can really do — but in a limited way?"

"But nothing too shocking," Nancy said. "We don't want another Charles incident."

In the background, a portrait of Sam briefly made a face, which everyone had the good manners not to acknowledge.

"I'm thinking we start with classic clips, then transition to interactive elements. Show how the AI can analyze comedic timing, help writers punch up their material..."

Nancy leaned forward, excitement building. "And then demonstrate how it preserves each comedian's unique style! Remember Earl saying in the square, Council's always worried about losing what made each performer special."

"Exactly. It's not about replacing anyone — it's about keeping their legacy alive in a new way."

"Mr. K, I think I found something that might help with the presentation."

Larry had entered carrying a very cool-looking tablet.

Derek looked up, surprised. "Gee, Larry, I didn't know you were still here working, or Miss Nancy and I would have invited you to stay and have dinner with us and Smithers."

"Gee, Mr. K, that is awful nice of you and Miss Nancy, but truth be told, old Smithers made me a huge lunch a couple hours ago... But I really appreciate the thought."

"Well, hopefully another time. So, what've you got, Larry?"

Larry placed the tablet on the table. "Check this out — it's an old project of Mr. Rhodes'. He called it 'Comedy DNA.'"

A holographic display sprang to life above the tablet, showing intricate patterns of interconnected comedic styles and influences — glowing threads linking name to name across the decades.

Nancy leaned in. "Are those... comedy family trees?"

"Exactly. It shows how different comedians influenced each other, their signature patterns, catchphrases, even their timing. The AI can analyze any routine and show its historical connections."

"That's perfect!" Derek said, excitement rising. "We start with Sam's influence tree, show how his style evolved..."

"Then demonstrate how the AI can help new comedians develop their own unique branches while honoring their roots!"

"Might I suggest a practical demonstration, sir?" Smithers offered. "Perhaps with a volunteer from the Council?"

"You mean let them try it themselves? That's risky..."

"But brilliant," Nancy said. "They can't argue with their own experience."

"I wonder if that would require the subject person to wear one of those caps Jonathan demonstrated in the basement?"

"You want me to see if I can find some of those things, Mr. K?"

"Ya, Larry, and I am thinking we need some additional equipment to pull off what we are talking about pulling off. There must be portable equipment if they performed for the council before."

"Now you're cooking with gas, kids!" AISAM's voice rolled through the speakers. "Just make sure they sign a waiver first. Some of those Council members look like they haven't laughed since the Carter administration."

Larry pulled up another hologram showing a mock presentation outline.

"We could structure it like this: Start with the history, show the technology, then the practical application. End with the volunteer demonstration."

"And for the finale..." Derek began.

Suddenly, the chandelier dimmed. The room went semi-dark, and a spotlight appeared in the center of the floor. The vintage record player abruptly switched to "Stayin' Alive" — and

Holographic Sam materialized in the spotlight, dressed in full John Travolta white-suit glory.

Sam struck the iconic pose, one finger to the sky.

"We give 'em the old razzle-dazzle!"

And he launched into a perfect recreation of Travolta's famous dance sequence, complete with pointing and hip swings, as the floor beneath him transformed into the glowing lit panels straight out of the movie.

Nancy was laughing before she could stop herself — a real laugh, the unguarded kind, the first one the house had gotten out of her since the basement. "Oh my god, is he...?"

"Yep," Derek said. "Ladies and gentlemen, the ghost of disco past."

Sam spun and slid across the dining room, his white suit glowing under the spotlight, while various portraits on the walls began dancing in sync with him — generations of stern Victorian faces suddenly discovering their hips.

Larry checked his tablet. "The AI's recording this for movement analysis. Apparently, it can break down dance moves the same way it analyzes comedy timing."

Nancy leaned toward Derek. "Please tell me we're not including this in the presentation."

"No promises. Though watching the Council try to do the hustle might be worth losing our house." Derek let out a big smile with raised eyebrows at Nancy.

Sam finished with a flourish and struck the final pose, pointing dramatically at Derek and Nancy.

"Oh oh ohhhh! And that's how you close a show, kids!"

The spotlight faded and the chandelier returned to normal. Sam's image reappeared in the mirror, where he adjusted his white suit and grinned.

"Now, about that presentation..." Then, yelling as only Sam does: "...who's ready to make comedy history?"

Derek raised his wine glass. "To the future of comedy."

Nancy joined the toast. "And to whatever crazy thing this house does next."

"Very good, sir and madam," Smithers said. "Shall I prepare coffee in the study? I believe Mr. Leland has finished setting up the holographic projector for your rehearsal."

"Perfect. Smithers, maybe bring me a bottle of port and some select sharp cheeses. I think I feel a 'Letter Guide For Rebecca'-like night may be in the cards. Nancy, ready to help me save comedy?"

Nancy stood. "After that dinner? I'd help you save anything. Except maybe Charles's dignity."

They exited arm in arm, following Larry, as Smithers began clearing the table. In the mirror, Sam remained in his white suit, striking one last Travolta pose.

"Now that's what I call dinner AND a show!"

The dining room emptied slowly, "Stayin' Alive" fading out as the vintage album resumed playing softly, the sound of laughter echoing on and on through the mansion's halls.

Two days to the big show. A council to win, a house to keep, a legacy the size of a quantum computer humming under their feet. In the gallery of portraits along the main hall, a hundred painted faces settled back into their frames, still ever so slightly out of breath from the dancing, and Ravencrest — patient, ancient, and thoroughly entertained — began quietly setting the stage.

□ □ □

So there it is, kids. The lady's in on the joke, the nursery's down the hall, and the Big Shoe is two days out. You want to know the secret to a great finale? It ain't the suit. It ain't even the dance floor. It's knowing your audience — and this house has been studying its audience for a very, very long time. OH, OH, OHHHHHHH!

□ □ □

COMEDY DNA: A FIELD GUIDE

From the archives of Lab 1D. Annotations in the margin appear to be in Sam's handwriting.

KINISON, SAM. Root system: fire-and-brimstone preaching (unpaid), scream therapy (self-administered), and every open-micer who ever died on a Tuesday night. Primary branches: the Scream, the Rant, the Third OH. Cross-pollination detected with: Pryor (danger), Dangerfield (timing), Berle (allegedly — *I'll sue, kid*). Signature mutation: turning pain into volume and volume into love. Growth pattern: cut short April 10, 1992. Root system: still alive. Very much still alive.

Margin note: Family trees are funny things, kid. You spend your whole life trying to be an original, and then some machine in a basement shows you that you were a branch all along. Here's the punchline — branches are how the tree keeps going. See you at the big show.

END OF BOOK FIVE

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca